The Make in India objective flows partly from the second objective. The government has been proactive and committed to FDI, though sometimes the ambivalence towards foreign technology imports becomes apparent. This provides a major contextual difference from the 1950s. This policy encourages foreign companies to set up manufacturing facilities in India, partly to serve rising domestic demand as well. Some investments will definitely flow to India to take advantage of PLI schemes and import duty differentiation.

The goal of self-reliance has not been spelt out in specific targets or timelines in terms of import reduction, export increase or current account surplus. Such targets may not be essential but there should be some specified anchors to judge the success of the policy.

All considered, the vocal campaign for self-reliance is unlikely to have a major impact on the trajectory of India’s import dependence or export growth. It appears that this slogan, too, will be another entry in the history of India—hopefully, without causing negative consequences for the economy.